

Steven Landers

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ENGINEERING EXECUTIVE & AI-NATIVE TECHNICAL LEADER

Engineering Leadership | Agentic Engineering | Distributed Systems | Blockchain Infrastructure | Security | MBA

Engineering executive and hands-on architect with 20 years building products, leading senior engineering teams, and operating distributed, security-sensitive systems under high throughput, financial risk, and adversarial conditions. Former CTO of Forta. Currently leading consensus and execution engineering and the AI transition at Sei Labs.

- **Leadership scope:** Led nine engineers as Director of Development / CTO of Forta, which raised \$23 million from a16z, and earlier led up to 21 engineers and UX professionals, including other managers, as a Director at Vonage.
- **AI transition:** Led the transition to agentic, spec-driven development at Sei Labs, keeping architecture, security, code review, and deployment under human ownership.
- **Technical depth:** Led the architecture and implementation of Sei's parallelized EVM and multi-proposer consensus platform, designed for roughly 200,000 transactions per second.
- **Zero to one:** Helped grow Forta from a laptop prototype to roughly 12,000 nodes, co-founded Netvote, and launched Pindrop's Cloud Protect fraud platform.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Sei Labs

2023–Present

L7 Engineer (Manager), Consensus & Execution Team

- Managed the five-engineer consensus and execution team delivering the Sei Giga architecture incrementally to mainnet, and led the transition to agentic, spec-driven development.

AI Transition

- Led the transition to agentic, spec-driven development as the primary way of building, combining agent skills and guardrails, repository-level instructions, automated validation, and human review.
- Built agent skills that turned machine-readable specs into pull requests, and workflows that generated code, ran tests, and investigated failures, while retaining ownership of architecture, security, and code review.

Sei Giga

- Led the design, prototyping, and rollout of Sei Giga, a multi-proposer architecture based on a modified Autobahn consensus protocol, designed for 5 gigagas per second (roughly 200,000 transactions per second).
- Drove technical design across consensus, execution, performance, and production rollout; co-authored two published papers on multi-proposer architecture and MEV (see Publications).

Sei Parallelized EVM

- Designed and implemented Block-STM parallel transaction execution for Sei's Cosmos-based EVM, making Sei the first parallelized EVM, and moved the design from prototype into production.
- Designed deterministic state-conflict detection, transaction validation, and conflict-resolution mechanisms, with sequential fallback to preserve correctness and mitigate pathological conflict and denial-of-service scenarios.

OpenZeppelin / Forta

2020–2023

Director of Development / CTO, Forta

Forta

- Led Forta's nine-engineer team, owning architecture, roadmaps, design reviews, and performance management.
- Served as principal architect for Forta, a decentralized transaction-monitoring and threat-detection network that raised \$23 million from a16z, growing it from a laptop proof of concept to roughly 12,000 production nodes.
- Scaled the platform to more than 13,000 subscribers and more than 900 detection bots continuously monitoring transactions across Ethereum, BNB Smart Chain, Avalanche, Polygon, Arbitrum, and Optimism.
- Helped deliver the network protocol, cloud infrastructure, blockchain integrations, token launch, airdrop, and developer platform.

OpenZeppelin Defender

- Principal architect for Defender, a security-first DevSecOps platform for Web3 projects, designed as a scalable AWS serverless application supporting transaction operations, monitoring, automation, and blockchain infrastructure.
- Built systems for reliable JSON-RPC provider access, transaction retry and fee repricing, automated operational tasks, and transaction monitoring.
- Developed the decentralized monitoring proof of concept that became Forta and transitioned to leading Forta full time after funding.

Bishop Fox

2019–2020

Principal Engineer & Software Manager

- Managed a five-engineer team building a high-scale continuous attack-surface and vulnerability-detection platform for Fortune 500 customers.
- Designed and launched cloud-asset ingestion into security analytics systems, and built a domain-discovery system using SSL certificate analysis, WHOIS data, and remote asset lookups.

Netvote (side venture)

2017–2019

Co-Founder & Technical Director

- Co-founded an anonymous, tamper-resistant voting platform built on Ethereum and other distributed-ledger technologies, designing a protocol that integrated blockchain-based voting with modern election processes.
- Delivered production elections with Govurn, including the RChain cooperative board election (2018).

Pindrop

2016–2019

Software Architect

- Led a small team that designed, built, and launched Cloud Protect, a cloud-based fraud platform adopted by multiple large financial customers.
- Architected real-time fraud-detection, authentication, and ML pipelines used by major banks and enterprise call centers, helping evolve the data architecture toward approximately three billion analyzed calls per year.
- Led cross-functional efforts to scale concurrent call-processing capacity, and delivered recurring architectural briefings to engineering, sales, and executive audiences.

Vocalocity / Vonage

2010–2016

Director of Software Architecture (previously Director of Development, Development Manager)

- Promoted three times in six years, from Software Engineer to Director; led teams of as many as 21 software engineers and UX professionals, including other managers.
- Helped scale Vocalocity's business communications platform before and after its acquisition by Vonage, coordinating distributed teams in Atlanta, New Jersey, and Tel Aviv.
- Designed systems for provisioning, billing, authentication, emergency calling, call-event processing, and telecommunications routing.

Earlier Experience

- **CGI Group, Consultant** | 2006–2010: Built and operated telecom, billing, portal, and set-top-box systems.

SKILLS & EXPERTISE

Leadership: Engineering leadership, technical strategy, roadmaps, performance management, managing managers, cloud and headcount budgets, distributed and cross-functional teams, executive briefings

AI-native engineering: Agentic and spec-driven development, agent skills and guardrails, machine-readable specs, automated validation, human-in-the-loop review, ML pipelines

Systems: Distributed systems, consensus protocols, parallel execution, blockchain architecture, security platforms, fraud detection, real-time and event-driven architecture, high-availability systems

Languages & platforms: Go, Python, TypeScript, Java, Solidity, AWS, Terraform, Kubernetes, Docker, PostgreSQL, MySQL, DynamoDB, Kafka, Redis, Elasticsearch

EDUCATION

MBA, University of Georgia, 2012 | **BS, Computer Science**, University of Georgia, 2005

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS AND PROJECTS

- Sei Giga, co-author (arxiv.org/abs/2505.14914)
- MEV in Multiple Concurrent Proposer Blockchains, first author (arxiv.org/abs/2511.13080)
- Forta: github.com/forta-network | docs.forta.network | forta.org